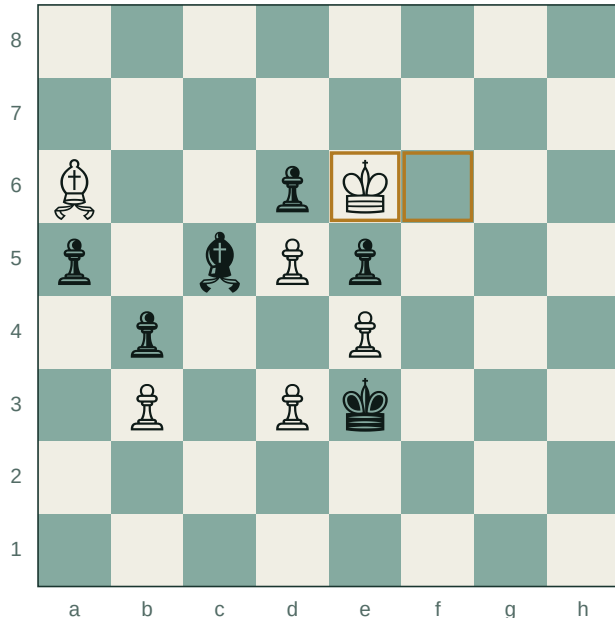


Bishop-ending decisions: Black, move 61

Bishop-ending decisions

Black to move



Previous move: 61.Ke6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

61...a4 62. bxa4 b3 63. Bc4 b2 64. Ba2 Kxd3

61...a4 The pawn moves from a5 to a4. Recorded reply: **62.bxa4**.

62...b3 The pawn moves from b4 to b3. Recorded reply: **63.Bc4**.

63...b2 The pawn moves from b3 to b2. Recorded reply: **64.Ba2**.

64...Kxd3 The king captures the pawn on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 6 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +0**: the balance goes from +0 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Same-colored and opposite-colored bishop endings have different tendencies, but neither label replaces calculation of the actual pawn races.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A bishop ending depends on diagonal access, pawn color, king activity, and promotion squares. Tactics can arise when a bishop must perform two defensive jobs.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the bishop's line to each target and identify pawns that can break its coverage or force it to move.

The defending king is on e6. Geometrically undefended: bishop on a6. Check for tactical protection.